Through the power of his will and the genius of his batting, Virat literally dragged us, his teammates, through the group phase, into the top two in the league and on to the play-offs.

It was anything but a smooth ride. Our opening win was followed by five defeats in the next six matches as our bowlers struggled to execute their plans. As a team, we were struggling to defend anything and, barely halfway through the tournament, we were facing early elimination and needing to win, and win, and win again.

Virat kept batting and batting, and we beat Rising Pune Supergiants at the Chinnaswamy, and then squeaked to a one-run win at Kings XI Punjab, suffered a defeat at home to Mumbai Indians, and eventually found ourselves needing to win each of our last four group matches to have any chance of progressing.

Momentum is a powerful force in Twenty20 tournaments and, driven on by our growing self-belief, we overcame Gujarat Lions at home, won against Kolkata Knight Riders in Kolkata, beat Kings XI Punjab at home and then, carefully, won a low-scoring match away at Delhi Daredevils to clinch our qualification.

Everything seemed to be falling into place. The complex play-off format meant that we had earned two chances to secure a place in the IPL final, and the first arrived in the form of a qualifier against the Gujarat Lions, a match to be played at a predetermined 'neutral' venue ... the Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru.

It was odd to see our home stadium dressed in neutral signage, but there was nothing neutral about the crowd and our bowlers performed exceptionally well to restrict Gujarat to 158 in their 20 overs. We launched our chase in a reasonably confident frame of mind but, as if to prove that anything really can happen in T20 cricket, we found ourselves in a crisis at 29 for five in the sixth over.

I had managed to survive and, together with Stuart Binny, was content to take singles and twos, and to punish anything short or loose. We